Johann Jakob Bachofen — Das Mutterrecht (1861)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Johann Jakob Bachofen of Basel, a jurist trained in law and drawn to antiquities, who followed myth, religion, and law through Lycia, Crete, Athens, and many other ancient places to build one large and difficult argument. His claim that the earliest societies were ordered through the mother would not stay quiet. Engels drew on it, and classical scholarship still wrestles with it, so that a book published in 1861 seeded a century of argument about how families, property, and worship were first arranged. English readers have so far received that argument in selections and shortened chapters. This presentation is dedicated to Bachofen in the hope that his whole book, in its own order and at its own length, may one day be read in English as he published it.

The author's own terms

Mother right, in Bachofen's sense, is the ordering of a society through the mother: descent, inheritance, and cult reckoned through her, before the patriarchal order displaced it.

The story

In 1861 a Basel jurist and antiquarian named Johann Jakob Bachofen (1815–

1887) published a large, difficult book with a simple and startling claim at its centre. *Das Mutterrecht: eine Untersuchung über die Gynaikokratie der alten Welt nach ihrer religiösen und rechtlichen Natur* — in English, an inquiry into the "gynaecocracy," or rule associated with women, of the ancient world, in its religious and legal nature — argues that the earliest human societies were ordered by "mother right": descent, inheritance, and cult reckoned through the mother, before the patriarchal order displaced it. Whatever a reader makes of the argument, the book would not stay quiet. Engels drew on it, and classical scholarship still wrestles with it. It seeded a century of argument about how families, property, and worship were first arranged.

That influence makes its English history surprising. English readers have met Bachofen in selections and in single chapters, sometimes carefully and sometimes in shortened form, but the whole 1861 book in English is another matter. The record set out below is plain: after research, no complete English translation was found.

Bachofen was a man of Basel, trained in law and drawn to antiquities. His book is not a short essay that grew in the telling. In its German first edition it runs to about 505 pages, moving through ancient places and peoples — Lycia, Crete, and Athens prominent among them — as it builds its case from myth, religion, and law. To read it whole, in its own order and at its own length, an English reader still has to wait, or learn German.

The work and what survives

The complete German first edition survives and is openly available. It is scanned on Internet Archive, under identifiers including `dasmutterrechte00bachgoog`, `dasmutterrechtei0000bach`, and `bub_gb_FYEBAAAAQAAJ`, and it is also on Google Books. The work is in the public domain: the author died in 1887, and the imprint is 1861.

So nothing essential is lost. The text is there, complete, in German. What is missing is not the book itself but its passage into English at full length.

Its English fortunes

The best-known English volume is *Myth, Religion, and Mother Right* (Bollingen LXXXIV, Princeton, 1967; translated by Ralph Manheim). It is explicitly a volume of selected writings — excerpts from *Mutterrecht* alongside other works — and it

should be described in exactly those terms, not as the book complete.

David Partenheimer's Edwin Mellen volumes (2006–2008) go further into the text itself, translating individual chapters: Lycia, Crete, and Athens; Lemnos and Egypt; and the Epizephyrian Locrians and Lesbos. Their own reviewers describe them as carefully abridged. Internet Archive also carries the Partenheimer volume as a lending item (`englishtranslati0000bach`), confirming its partial scope.

The bounded finding of this research, verified on 14 October 2026 through publisher pages, AbeBooks edition records, and LibraryThing series data, is this: **No complete English translation found after research.**

What completing it would take

Completing the work in English would mean a full fresh translation from the 1861 German, about 505 pages, issued in instalments — the Lycia, Crete, and Athens core first — with a framing dedication by the presenter. It is large but divisible, and the review standard set for it is a German reader together with a classicist.

Until that is done, the honest summary stands. Bachofen's argument changed how later writers thought about the ancient family, and English has received it in pieces: a distinguished selection, and abridged chapters. The whole book, as Bachofen published it in 1861, has not been found in English.

Sources

- https://www.abebooks.com/9780710029799/Myth-Religion-Mother-Right-Selected-0710029799/plp (Bollingen volume synopsis: "Selected Writings")
- https://www.abebooks.com/9780773451865/English-Translation-Bachofens-Mutterrecht-Mother-0773451862/plp (Partenheimer vol. 1, Lycia/Crete/Athens, 88 pp.)
- https://www.iberlibro.com/9780773454798/Lemnos-Egypt-English-Translation-Bachofens-0773454799/plp (Partenheimer vol. 2)
- https://www.abebooks.com/9780773462984/English-Translation-Bachofens-Mutterrecht-Mother-0773462988/plp (Partenheimer, Locrians/Lesbos volume; review notes the abridgement)
- Internet Archive advanced search, 2026-10-14: title:(mutterrecht) AND creator:(bachofen) — 10 items incl. the German scans above.